

Legalism Denial

doc-legalism-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · outside_majority_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Adding human rules to God's commands as conditions of acceptance, fellowship, or sanctification, and treating obedience as the ground rather than the fruit of grace, distorts the gospel.

In plain language

The biblical words draw a sharp line between how a person comes into right standing with God and what people add on their own. The Greek verb for being justified or declared righteous (dikaioo) is repeatedly negated and set against the phrase 'works of law' (ergon nomou). In Galatians 2:16 that phrase appears three times in one verse, and Romans 3:20 says no flesh will be justified by works of law, so doing law-deeds cannot be the basis of acceptance. The same negated pattern recurs across Galatians 3 and Romans 2 to 9, which shows it is a settled usage and not a one-letter argument. The means is named instead as faith (pistis). Galatians 5 sharpens this: a person who takes on circumcision as a condition becomes a debtor to keep the whole law, and those who seek to be justified in law 'were severed from Christ' (katergethete apo Christou) and 'fell out of grace' (tes charitos exepesate), with verbs that mark a decisive cutting off. The Gospels add the same picture from a different angle. In Mark 7 worship becomes empty when people teach as doctrines 'the commandments of men' (entalmata anthronon), and the 'commandment' (entole) of God is set against the 'tradition' (paradosis) of men. In Matthew 23 the leaders tie up heavy, hard-to-bear burdens and lay them on others. Colossians 2 calls food, festival, and sabbath rules the precepts and teachings of men, self-made worship (ethelothreskia) that looks wise but has no power against the flesh, using the very same wording as Mark 7. Obedience is never denied. What is denied is making added human rules or law-keeping the basis of acceptance. The one verse that seems to push back, James 2:24, says a person is justified by works and not by faith alone, using the same two Greek words. Readers can diverge here because the words alone do not rank the two statements. The tension eases at the text level: James drops the qualifier 'of law' and speaks of a bare, dead faith, so he means works that show a living faith, while Paul means works of law offered as the basis of standing. Same word, two senses, settled by context.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioo	to justify	38
G1479	ἐθελοθησκία	ethelothreskia	self-made religion	1
G1601	ἐκπίπτω	ekpiptō	to fall out	
G1778	ἐνταλμα	entalma	precept	3
G1785	ἐντολή	entole	commandment	63
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	176

G2671	κατάρα	katara	curse	
G2673	καταργέω	katargeō	to abate	
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	196
G3759	ούαί	ouai	woe!	
G3862	παράδοσις	paradosis	tradition	13
G4102	πίστις	pistis	faith	243
G5273	ὑποκριτής	hypokrites	hypocrite	19
G5330	Φαρισαῖος	Pharisaios	Pharisee	99
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	570

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The denial of works-of-law as a basis for acceptance is dense and runs across all of Paul's letters, not just one. The pairing of the words 'work' (erga, G2041) and 'law' (nomos, G3551) recurs in Galatians 2:16, 3:2, 3:5, 3:10 and Romans 2:15, 3:20, 3:27, 3:28, 9:32, and in those same verses the verb 'to justify' or 'to declare righteous' (dikaioo, G1344) is negated with 'not' (ou) or 'no one' (oudeis), so being justified 'out of works of law' (ex ergon nomou) is shut out (Galatians 2:16 stacks the negated present passive 'is justified' (dikaiooutai), which is an ongoing simple statement of fact in the receiving voice, three times, Romans 3:20 the future passive 'will not be justified' (ou dikaiouthesetai) for 'all flesh' (pasa sarx)). Galatians 5:3-4 makes accepting circumcision as a condition a debt to keep the whole law, with the result that they 'were severed from Christ' (katergethete apo Christou) and 'fell out of grace' (tes charitos exepesate). In the Gospels Mark 7:7-9 opposes the 'commandment' (entole) of God (G1785) to the 'tradition' (paradosis) of men (G3862), and Colossians 2:22 repeats the exact phrase 'commandments and teachings of men' (entalmata kai didaskalias ton anthropon), branding food, festival, and sabbath rules as 'self-imposed worship' (ethelothreskia, G1479) with no power against the flesh. The texts therefore support the proposition: conditions made of human rules, and law-works treated as the basis of acceptance, distort the gospel, while obedience remains its fruit.

Scripture

Gal.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμος, G4102 πίστις

Reasoning. The clause 'a man is not justified out of works of law' (ou dikaiooutai anthropos ex ergon nomou) pairs the negated present passive of 'to justify' (dikaioo, G1344, parsed as V-PPI-3S, an ongoing simple statement of fact in the receiving voice, third person singular) with 'works of law' (ergon nomou, the word for 'work' G2041 in the 'of-works' grammatical form, plural, plus the word for 'law' G3551 in the 'of-law' grammatical form, singular) as the supposed basis of acceptance. The phrase 'works of law' recurs three times in this one verse, and the contrasting 'through faith' (dia pisteos) and 'out of faith' (ek pisteos), using the noun for 'faith' (pistis, G4102), names faith, not rule-keeping, as the means. The triple negation drives the either-or home.

Rom.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμος

Reasoning. 'Out of works of law no flesh will be justified' (ex ergon nomou ou dikaiothesetai pasa sarx) puts the future passive of 'to justify' (dikaioo, G1344, parsed as V-FPI-3S, a future simple statement of fact in the receiving voice, third person singular) under negation, so no flesh will be declared righteous out of works of law. This is the same word-pattern as Galatians 2:16 in a different letter, which shows the negation is not confined to the Galatian dispute but is a settled way Paul writes. The clause closes by assigning the law the role of giving knowledge of sin, not of serving as the basis of right standing.

Gal.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμος, G2671 κατάρα

Reasoning. 'For as many as are out of works of law are under a curse' (hosoi gar ex ergon nomou eisin hypo kataran eisin) places those whose standing rests on works of law under a 'curse' (katara, G2671), grounded in the citation that everyone is cursed who does not continue in all that is written to do it. The text makes 'law as basis' self-defeating, since the law itself pronounces a curse on incomplete obedience.

Gal.5.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Reasoning. 'Every man who accepts circumcision is a debtor to do the whole law' (panti anthropo peritemnomeno...opheiletes estin holon ton nomon poiesai) states that every 'man' (anthropos, G0444) who accepts circumcision as a condition becomes a 'debtor' (opheiletes, G3781) to keep the whole 'law' (nomos, G3551). The word-level point is that adopting one imposed rule as a basis of standing obligates the entire law, which verse 4 then ties to being severed from Christ.

Gal.5.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G3551 νόμος, G5547 Χριστός

Reasoning. 'You were severed from Christ' (katergethete apo Christou, the verb 'to sever' G2673 as a completed past action in the receiving voice) and 'you fell out of grace' (tes charitos exepesate, the verb 'to fall out' G1601 also a completed past action) describe the result for 'whoever among you are being justified in law' (hoitines en nomo dikaiothe), those seeking justification in law (the verb 'to justify' dikaioo, G1344, as an ongoing simple statement of fact in the receiving voice). The completed-past-action verbs mark a decisive break and treat 'law as basis' as forfeiture of grace, the sharpest word-level statement that such conditioning distorts the gospel.

Mark.7.7 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1778 ἔνταλμα, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Reasoning. 'Teaching as doctrines the commandments of men' (didaskontes didaskalias entalmata anthropon, the word for 'commandment' entalma, G1778, plus the word for 'man' anthropos, G0444) makes worship 'in vain' (maten, G3155), and verses 8 to 9 contrast the 'commandment' (entole, G1785) of God with the 'tradition' (paradosis, G3862) of men, using the verbs 'leaving aside' (aphentes), 'you set aside' (atheteite), and 'you establish' (stesete) to mark the human rule as a displacement of the divine command. The word-level opposition between God's command and human tradition is explicit.

Matt.23.4 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G5273 ὑποκριτής

Reasoning. 'They tie up heavy and hard-to-bear burdens' (desmeuousin de phortia barea kai dysbastakta) and lay them on the shoulders of men while refusing to move them with a finger. The picture in the words is added human obligation imposed as a load, and the surrounding woes label the speakers 'hypocrites' (hypokritai, G5273) and 'blind ones' (tuphloi), framing rule-multiplication as failure rather than the path of acceptance.

Col.2.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1778 ἔνταλμα, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G1479 ἐθελοθρησκία

Reasoning. 'According to the commandments and teachings of men' (kata ta entalmata kai didaskalias ton anthropon, the word for 'commandment' entalma, G1778, plus the word for 'man' anthropos, G0444) describes the touch-taste-handle prohibitions and the food, festival, new-moon, and sabbath rules of the surrounding verses. Verse 23 calls them 'self-imposed worship' (ethelothreskia, G1479), having an appearance of wisdom but no value against the indulgence of the flesh. The phrase 'commandments and teachings of men' (entalmata kai didaskalias ton anthropon) matches Mark 7:7 word for word, a cross-book lexical echo.

Phil.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G4102 πίστις

Reasoning. 'Not having my own righteousness which is out of law but that which is through faith of Christ' (me echon emen dikaiosynen ten ek nomou alla ten dia pisteos Christou) sets a righteousness 'out of law' (ek nomou, the word 'law' nomos, G3551) against a righteousness 'through faith' (dia pisteos) and 'out of God upon faith' (ek theou epi te pistei), using the word for 'faith' (pistis, G4102). The contrast of the two sources of 'righteousness' (dikaiosyne, G1343) confirms in a third letter that law-keeping is not the basis of right standing, faith is.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gal.3.10	Deut.27.26	tsk	1
Gal.5.3	Deut.8.19	tsk	1
Mark.7.10	Exod.21.17	tsk	1
Mark.7.9	2Kgs.16.10	tsk	1
Col.2.18	Col.2.23	tsk	1
Gal.2.21	Gal.2.18	tsk	1
Matt.23.4	Matt.23.23	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jas.2.24 · addressed

'You see that a man is justified out of works and not out of faith only' (horate hoti ex ergon dikaioutai anthropos kai ouk ek pisteos monon) uses the identical word-forms 'to justify' (dikaioo, G1344) and 'works' (erga, G2041) as Galatians 2:16 and Romans 3:20 but states the opposite surface claim, that a man is justified by works and not by faith alone. The vocabulary alone does not rank the two patterns, which is the genuine word-level tension. It resolves on two text-level cues that the words supply. First, Paul attaches the 'of-law' form of 'law' (nomou, meaning 'works of law') and James does not, so James is not addressing law-keeping as the meritorious basis at all. Second, James targets 'out of faith only' (ek pisteos monon), a bare or dead faith (verses 17 and 26 call such faith 'dead' (nekra)), so 'to justify' (dikaioo) in James carries the demonstrative sense of being shown righteous by fruit, while in Paul it carries the legal-declaration sense of being declared righteous as to basis. The same word, two attested senses, sorted out by context, so James does not overturn the negation of law-works as basis.

Matt.23.3 · addressed

'Therefore whatever they tell you, do and keep' (panta oun hosa ean eiposin hymin poiesate kai tereite) commands obedience to what the leaders teach from Moses' seat, which could appear to endorse their rule-system. The word-level context resolves it: verse 3b condemns their practice ('but do not do according to their works', kata de ta erga auton me poieite) and verse 4 names their added 'burdens' (phortia) as heavy loads. The endorsement attaches to the Mosaic content they recite, not to the human 'tradition' (paradosis) that the parallel Mark 7 explicitly rejects, so it does not support 'rule as basis'.

Gal.2.17 · addressed

'We ourselves also were found sinners, may it never be' (heurethemen kai autoi hamartoloi, me genoito) raises whether justification apart from law-works makes Christ a servant of sin. Paul answers with the emphatic 'may it never be' (me genoito, the negative G3361 plus a completed past action verb) and in verse 18 ties transgression to rebuilding what was torn down, so the verse reinforces rather than weakens the verdict that law cannot be the basis.

Concordance traversed

G1344, G2041, G3551, G3862, G1785, G1778, G1479, G5273, G5330, G5547, G4102, G0444, G2673, G1601, G2671, G3759

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All cited verses lie outside the open-cbgm 3 John ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) sample, and not_in_ecm_scope is true in the bundle, so the verdict is treated as ecm-shadow. The direct lexical query confirmed the readings that carry the verdict: the triple 'out of works of law' (ex ergon nomou) plus negated 'is justified' (dikaoutai) in Galatians 2:16, the future passive in Romans 3:20, and 'you were severed from Christ' (katergethete apo Christou) in Galatians 5:4 are stable and not text-critically contested in a way that touches the proposition.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. law_gospel_distinction, covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

law_gospel_distinction: affirms · Reads Galatians 2:16 and 5:4 as a categorical contrast between law as basis and faith as instrument, so the negated 'to justify' (dikaioo) plus 'work of law' (ergon nomou) shuts out law-keeping as a basis of acceptance, and adding human rules as conditions distorts the gospel.

covenant_theology: affirms · Treats the moral law as the rule of the redeemed life but not its basis. Paul targets 'work of law' (ergon nomou) as a basis of standing while obedience remains the fruit of grace, which matches the fruit-not-basis ordering in the proposition. The continuing function of the moral law is a separate question the verdict does not need to settle.

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Locates the believer under the law of Christ rather than the Mosaic statute and reads the Galatians and Colossians polemic, including 'self-imposed worship' (ethelothreskia) in Colossians 2:23, as rejecting any human-rule supplement to grace, consistent with the verdict.

works-evidential reading (James 2 weighting): affirms · Gives full weight to James 2:24, where 'a man is justified out of works' (ex ergon dikaoutai anthropos) uses the same word-forms to opposite surface effect. On its strongest form this lens still affirms the proposition, because James addresses works as the demonstrative fruit that shows a living faith, not works of law as the meritorious basis, so it denies legalism while refusing antinomianism (the denial that any moral law binds the believer). The divergence is over the sense of 'to justify' (dikaioo), not over whether law-keeping is the basis.

All lenses converge that 'work of law' (ergon nomou) cannot be the basis of acceptance. The only word-level tension is the shared vocabulary of Paul and James around 'to justify' (dikaioo) and 'works' (erga), which the words underdetermine and context sorts out. The verdict does not depend on resolving the covenantal disagreement about the continuing role of the moral law.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Some texts address whether acceptance, fellowship, or sanctification (the process of being made holy) may be grounded on human rules added to God's commands, and whether obedience functions as the basis or the fruit of standing with God.

The original stem embeds the conclusion in the phrase 'distorts the gospel' and in the fruit-not-basis ordering, which presupposes a gospel-versus-legalism frame. The neutralized form states the question without the verdict so the lexical (word-level) data can be weighed on its own. The verdict above is derived on the original stem, and the negated 'to justify' (dikaioo) plus 'work of law' (ergon nomou) pattern across Galatians 2:16, 3:10, Romans 3:20, the 'commandment'-versus-'tradition' (entole-versus-paradosis) opposition in Mark 7:7-9, and the 'commandments of men' (entalmata ton anthropon) language in Colossians 2:22 independently support it. Prior 'affirms true' is retained, the direct query strengthened it without forcing a change. VERDICT-CHANGED: no.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gal.2.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.3.20
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gal.5.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mark.7.7
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Col.2.22
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jas.2.24
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1344
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3862
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gal.3.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.2.18

License audit

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